City of Cambridge

POR 2026-182
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 28, 2026

MAYOR SIDDIQUI
COUNCILLOR SOBRINHO-WHEELER
COUNCILLOR MCGOVERN
COUNCILLOR AL-ZUBI

WHEREAS: Head Start is a federal grant program that provides high-quality early education and comprehensive services, including health, mental health, nutrition, disability, and family supports, to children from birth to age 5 from families living below the federal poverty level, families experiencing homelessness, children in foster care, and children with disabilities; and

WHEREAS: Head Start serves over 10,000 young children each year in Massachusetts through 28 agencies, including Community Action Agency of Somerville (CAAS) which serves Cambridge children and families; and

WHEREAS: Head Start, launched in 1965 and governed by the Head Start Act, is regulated by the Head Start Program Performance Standards, which set a consistent minimum of quality for education, health and safety, workforce, and accountability while allowing programs to design services around local needs; and

WHEREAS: On August 6, 2026, the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) issued a Notice of Proposed Rulemaking (NPRM), "Reducing Federal Burden for Head Start Programs," that would rescind these standards and replace them with a much shorter framework that would, among other things:

- eliminate federal standards for teaching and learning, group size, ratios, and staff qualifications;
- remove prohibitions on the suspension and expulsion of young children;
- remove requirements for developmental screenings, mental health services, and health and dental care;
- end self-attestation of homelessness and child age when documentation is unavailable, threatening access for 8% of families nationwide;
- end the deduction of excess housing costs from income calculations, harming families in high-cost states like Massachusetts;
- require all education to be provided only in English and disallow incentives for bilingual educators;
- cut the allowable administrative cost cap from 15% to 5%; and

WHEREAS: The Massachusetts Head Start Association, along with other experts and advocates, has warned that the NPRM would have negative effects, including increasing class sizes, reducing the teacher workforce, lowering educator salaries, eliminating jobs and key roles such as bilingual educators, and making some children ineligible for programs; and

WHEREAS: Cambridge is a diverse, multilingual community, and amid this federal uncertainty the City must uphold support for Head Start programs play for children and families in Cambridge, and for our city as a whole; now therefore be it

RESOLVED: That the Cambridge City Council go on record in strong support of Head Start and the Program Performance Standards that ensure the teaching, learning, health, and welfare of children, families, and classrooms; and be it further

RESOLVED: That the City Council opposes the NPRM as written and urges HHS to withdraw it; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Clerk be and hereby is requested to forward suitably engrossed copies of this resolution to the Cambridge state legislative delegation, the Secretary of HHS, the Massachusetts Head Start Association, and CAAS leadership, on behalf of the entire City Council.

A true copy;

ATTEST:- Paula M. Crane

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk

City of Cambridge

That the City Council goes on record in strong support of Head Start and the Program Performance Standards that ensure the teaching, learning, health, and welfare of children, families, and classrooms.